CASTRO EVENTUALLY AGREED TO MEET WITH ALEKSANDR Alekseev on Monday, October 29, the day after Khrushchev's letter to Kennedy was broadcast. Alekseev had another letter for him, this one not from Khrushchev personally but from the entire Soviet leadership.

The Presidium wanted Castro to make a public statement supporting the Khrushchev-Kennedy deal: to "express in your own terms what we have already said." The idea had allegedly come from the Americans, a detail that Khrushchev expected to deflect Castro's wrath from him. To show that it was indeed the Americans and not Khrushchev who had proposed the idea, the Presidium sent Alekseev a transcript of a conversation between the KGB chief in Washington, Aleksandr Feklisov, and his American contact John Scali. Scali, whose name was not given in the transcript, had assured Feklisov, whose name was not there either, that such an initiative from Castro would be received positively in the United States. Khrushchev was trying to appease Castro and salve the wound to his pride by offering him a role in the settlement. But the role was that of endorsing a decision made without consulting him. Not surprisingly, Castro remained aloof, promising to study the proposal.[12]

"I have never yet encountered Castro so dispirited and irritable," reported Alekseev to Moscow. "We will not allow anyone to carry out any inspection in our land," Castro told the Soviet ambassador. He called the inspections a "humiliating procedure." He also attacked the Soviets where it hurt most, suggesting that they had caved in to the Americans: "an impression has been created that the Soviet Union yielded to pressure from the USA." To mollify Castro, Alekseev proposed to have Khrushchev send him a "warm" letter and make a public statement supporting Castro's five points.[13]

Khrushchev was now fully aware that he had a problem, and that it was getting worse. "Castro did not understand the full depth of the undertaking embodied in our action; he did not understand the political maneuver," recalled Khrushchev later. "He was highly nervous and lambasted us every which way, if one can put it like that. Castro's 'revolutionism,' his extremism was intensely fired up by the Chinese. And we suffered moral detriment. Instead of our stock rising in Cuba, it fell. Castro considered that we had betrayed Cuba while the Chinese were supporting it." At stake was